Say it to your boss.

A big goal can feel exciting and scary at the same time. This dossier gives you the research, the sentences and the grammar to talk to your boss about it.

NAME _____ DATE _____

This is your page for the lesson. The numbers and titles match the lesson on the screen. Write on the lines, circle your answer. **Bold on grey** is a chunk to learn. Dotted is a word to look up. The Portuguese for these words is on the last pages.

1 WARM UP

Where do you stand?

Before you read anything, tell us what you think. Circle the answer closest to your opinion. There is no right answer.

My boss explains why a goal matters.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I can say "this deadline is too short."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I work better when a goal is a little scary.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A number is better than "do your best."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I tell my boss about a problem early.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I stay quiet when I think my boss will be upset.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

How do goals reach you?

Think about your job. If you do not work, think about school or a course.

○ In a meeting, and my boss explains why.
○ By email or chat, with a number.
○ Only as "do your best."
○ I set my own goals.

Two numbers about you

Write your number, then compare it with a partner.

How clear are your goals at work or at school?

Move the slider. 0 is not clear at all. 100 is very clear.

My number _____ / 100

How easy is it to say no to your boss, a teacher or a coach?

Move the slider. 0 is very hard. 100 is very easy.

My number _____ / 100

Talk about these first

Then read the article and see who agrees with you.

1 Think of a goal that felt too big. Who gave it to you? What did you do?

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2 How do you usually receive a goal: in a meeting, by email or in a short message? Which one do you prefer?

---

3 When did you stay quiet, and you wish you had spoken? What was the **fear**?

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4 What is one sentence you would like to say to your boss, but you never say?

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5 Can a boss make it easy for you to speak up? How?

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2 ARTICLE

WORK · BOSSES

Four things to say to your boss

Four short sentences can make the talk with your boss easier. Here they are, with the research behind them.

By EIC Magazine · 3 min read

A big goal can feel **exciting** and **scary** at the same time. Most people do not say how they feel. They **nod**, they say "OK," and they **worry** alone.

In 1980, John Gabarro and John Kotter wrote "Managing Your Boss" for Harvard Business Review. Their main idea is simple: your relationship with your boss is part of your job, and you and your boss depend on each other. Here are four things you can say to make it better.

ASK FOR CLARITY

Do not **guess** what your boss wants. Gabarro and Kotter **advise** you to ask about **priorities** and **expectations**. A boss may say "do your best," but you need more than that. Ask for a number, a date and an example. Try this: "What does success look like?"

SAY IT EARLY

Bosses need to hear **bad news** early. Gabarro and Kotter say that a **promise** about an easy date can please your boss today and upset your boss later, if you do not keep it. One president in the article would rather have a **steady** employee than one with a few big successes. If a goal is in danger, say so today, not on the last day. Try this: "I see a risk."

DISAGREE CALMLY

Why is it hard to disagree? Jim Detert and Amy Edmondson studied this and published their research in 2011. They found that many people follow **unspoken** rules in their heads. People use these rules to decide if speaking up is safe, and they do it without thinking. These rules can keep people quiet in the **workplace**. So start small. Say what you agree with first. Then give one **fact** and one **option**: "I agree with the goal. The date worries me. Could we move it by one week?"

ASK FOR WHAT YOU NEED

A big goal needs time, people or **information**. Name what you need and say why: "I need this to do it well." Gabarro and Kotter add a **warning**: your boss's time is **limited**, so save your requests for the important things. The sentences to say are advice for this lesson, not research findings.

Before your next meeting, choose one sentence and say it out loud. The first time is the hardest. After that, it gets easier.

"I agree with the goal. The date worries me. Could we move it by one week?"

A sentence for this lesson

1980
the year Gabarro and Kotter published "Managing Your Boss" in Harvard Business Review

4 studies
in Detert and Edmondson's 2011 research on why people stay quiet at work

5 kinds
of unspoken rules about speaking up, measured in those studies

180 teams
studied by Google: psychological safety came first of five dynamics

Sources: Gabarro and Kotter, Managing Your Boss, Harvard Business Review (1980; reprinted 2005); Detert and Edmondson, Implicit Voice Theories: Taken-for-Granted Rules of Self-Censorship at Work, Academy of Management Journal (2011); Google re:Work, Understand team effectiveness.

Comments

6 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

Camila R. · Campinas · customer support
My boss asks for "the best you can do." I never know if that is 80 or 120. Now I ask, "What does success look like?" She answers with a number.

Rafael · Recife · developer
I told my manager about a **delay** on Monday, not on Friday. She was not happy, but she said thank you. We fixed it in two days.

Dona Lúcia · Curitiba · retired nurse
In my day, you did not say no to the **head nurse**. I wish somebody had taught me one polite sentence.

Tiago · Porto Alegre · sales
I disagree in private, never in the meeting. My boss gets very **upset** when someone corrects him in front of the team.

Júlia · Lisbon · designer
I asked for one more person. He said no. But he gave me two weeks without meetings, and that helped.

Marcos · Belo Horizonte · **intern**
I am new. Everybody is quiet in the meeting, so I am quiet too.

Words from the article

Hover on the screen, or look here.

advise
aconselhar

agree with
concordar com

bad news
más notícias

correct
corrigir

delay
atraso

depend on
depender de

do your best
faça o seu melhor

exciting
empolgante

expectation
expectativa

fact
fato

fix
consertar, resolver

guess
chutar, adivinhar

head nurse
enfermeira-chefe

I need this to do it well
preciso disso para fazer bem feito

I see a risk
vejo um risco

in danger
em risco

in private
em particular, a sós

information
informação

intern
estagiário

limited
limitado

nod
concordar com a cabeça

one more person
mais uma pessoa (na equipe)

option
opção

out loud
em voz alta

priority
prioridade

promise
promessa

scary
assustador

steady
constante, regular

the date worries me
o prazo me preocupa

unspoken
não dito, implícito

upset
chateado, aborrecido

warning
aviso, alerta

What does success look like?
como é o sucesso? (como saberemos que a meta foi atingida?)

workplace
ambiente de trabalho

worry
se preocupar

More words from the exercises

The same chunks and phrases, from sections 3 to 8.

at the last minute
em cima da hora

average
média

behind
atrasado

conditions
condições, situação atual

customer support
suporte ao cliente, atendimento

defend
defender

estimate
estimativa

fear
medo

I will try
vou tentar

keep your pace
manter o ritmo

leave
sair (da empresa)

let me know
me avise, me diga

no problem
sem problema

quarter
trimestre

quit
pedir demissão

score
nota, pontuação

start at
começar em (um número)

stupid
idiota, burro

success
sucesso

sweet spot
ponto ideal, faixa ideal

tool
ferramenta

track record
histórico de resultados

3 CHECK

What does the article say?

Facts first, then voices. Every answer is in the text or in the comments.

True or false?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? If it is false, write the correct fact on the line.

EXAMPLE "The article says you should guess what your boss wants."

False

It is false. The article says: do not guess. Ask.

1 "Gabarro and Kotter advise you to ask your boss about **priorities** and **expectations**."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

2 "Gabarro and Kotter say that a big **promise** about the date always makes the boss happy."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

3 "According to the article, bosses prefer to hear **bad news** at the last minute."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

4 "Detert and Edmondson studied why people stay quiet at work."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

5 "The article says you should say what you agree with before you disagree."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

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6 "People think carefully before they follow an unspoken rule about speaking up."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

Find the reader

All the answers are in the comments, below the article. Read them again and choose the name.

EXAMPLE Who says everybody is quiet in the meeting, so he is quiet too?

Marcos

Marcos says he is new, and everybody is quiet, so he is quiet too.

1 Who says she now asks "What does success look like?"

○ Rafael ○ Camila ○ Tiago

2 Who says he told his manager about a delay on Monday?

○ Rafael ○ Júlia ○ Marcos

3 Who says his boss gets upset when someone corrects him in front of the team?

○ Dona Lúcia ○ Camila ○ Tiago

4 Who says her boss said no to one more person, but gave her something else?

○ Júlia ○ Rafael ○ Marcos

4 FEARS

Why we stay quiet

Why do people stay quiet? Detert and Edmondson found that people follow unspoken rules in their heads, and they follow them without thinking. Often nobody checks if the fear is true. The four fears below are common examples, written for this lesson.

Four fears

1	**My boss will be offended.**
2	**It will hurt my career.**
3	**I will look weak.**
4	**I will be the only one.**

Which fear is it?

Read what each person thinks. Circle the fear behind the thought.

EXAMPLE Paulo thinks: "If I say no to this project, my boss will remember it when promotions come."

It will hurt my career.

He is thinking about his future at the company. That is the fear for his career.

1 The goal is too big. Ana thinks: "If I say 600 is too much, my boss will take it as a criticism of him."

○ I will look weak.
○ My boss will be offended.
○ It will hurt my career.

2 The deadline is too short. Bruno thinks: "If I ask for more time, they may give the next big project to someone else."

○ I will be the only one.
○ I will look weak.
○ It will hurt my career.

3 You need help. Carla thinks: "If I ask for help, everybody will see that I am not as good as the others."

○ It will hurt my career.
○ I will look weak.
○ My boss will be offended.

4 You need help too. Diego thinks: "Nobody else asks for help in this team. I do not want to be the first."

○ I will be the only one.
○ My boss will be offended.
○ It will hurt my career.

5 You see a mistake in the plan. Elisa thinks: “She wrote this plan herself. If I say there is a problem, she will be upset.”

- ◯ My boss will be offended.
- ◯ I will look weak.
- ◯ I will be the only one.

6 You disagree in a meeting. Fábio thinks: “If I disagree in front of everybody, my next review may be bad.”

- ◯ My boss will be offended.
- ◯ I will be the only one.
- ◯ It will hurt my career.

Has this fear ever really happened to you? Many people never test their fear.

YOUR TURN · YOUR FEAR

Think of one time you did not say something to a boss, a teacher or a coach. Which fear was it? Did it really happen?

5 CHUNKS

Chunks and patterns

The four things to say use the same phrases again and again. Learn the whole phrase and the pattern that goes with it, and the sentence builds itself.

Three families you already know

Three of the sentences you will say use verb patterns. The first verb decides what comes next. These are the same Families 1, 2 and 3 from the Verb Patterns lesson.

FAMILY	THE PATTERN	THE VERBS	EXAMPLE
1	**verb + person + to + verb**	ask · need · want · would like · expect	“I’d like you to explain the priority.”
2	**let · make · have + person + verb**	Only three verbs. No to after the person.	“Could you let me know if the plan changes?”
3	**suggest · recommend · propose + that + person + verb**	Formal. The verb stays in the base form: that we move, that she join.	“I suggest that we move the date by one week.”

Where the not goes

FAMILY	WHERE THE NOT GOES	EXAMPLE
1	**Two places**	“I didn’t ask them to start.” × “I asked them not to start.”
2	**The first verb**	“I didn’t let them start.” Never “I let them not start.”
3	**After that**	“I suggest that they not start.” Never “that they don’t start.”

Pick the chunk

Circle the words that complete the sentence. Each answer is a chunk, not a single word.

EXAMPLE My manager would like me _____ the plan on Monday.

to present

Family 1: would like + person + to + verb. The to belongs to the pattern.

1 I wrote to my boss to ask for _____ about the goal.

○ clearly ○ clarity ○ clear

2 If a goal is in _____, I say so today, not on the last day.

○ dangerously ○ dangerous ○ danger

3 I need you _____ me what the priority is.

○ to tell ○ telling ○ tell

4 Could you let me _____ if the plan changes?

○ to know ○ know ○ knowing

5 I suggest that we _____ the date by one week.

○ move ○ to move ○ moves

6 I asked her _____ to the client yet.

○ not to talk ○ not talk ○ don't talk

7 Please do not _____ a promise that you cannot keep.

○ do ○ make ○ take

8 My boss gave me a big goal, so I will _____ for what I need.

○ tell ○ say ○ ask

Write the missing word

Write one word in the space. Use the pattern from the lesson. The verb in brackets is the one you need.

EXAMPLE My teacher had us **read** the new words out loud. (read)

Have + person + verb, with no to. The verb stays in the base form.

1 I'd like you _____ look at the numbers with me.

2 My boss let me _____ my own plan. (write)

3 I suggest that he _____ the date with the team. (confirm)

4 I asked them _____ to wait for permission.

5 A good boss makes people _____ safe. (feel)

6 I asked, "What does success _____ like?" (look)

Where does the not go?

Read the situation. Circle the sentence that says it.

EXAMPLE You never asked Ana to stay late. She stayed because she wanted to.

I didn't ask Ana to stay late.

You made no request, so the not goes to the first verb: didn't ask.

1 You asked your boss: “Please do not change the deadline.”

- ○ I didn’t ask my boss to change the deadline.
- ○ I asked my boss not to change the deadline.

2 Your boss said no: nobody could work from home on Friday.

- ○ My boss didn’t let us work from home.
- ○ My boss let us not work from home.

3 Nobody ever told Rui to take the new project. He took it alone.

- ○ I told Rui not to take the project.
- ○ I didn’t tell Rui to take the project.

4 You write to your boss and recommend: no more meetings on Friday.

- ○ I suggest that we no have meetings on Friday.
- ○ I suggest us not to have meetings on Friday.
- ○ I suggest that we not have meetings on Friday.

6 LISTEN

The sentence you will say tomorrow

Three short moments between an employee and a boss. Open the lesson on the screen, go to section 6 and press play. The numbers match.

What did you hear?

Listen as many times as you like. Then circle your answer.

EXAMPLE **You hear:** “Thank you for telling me early. I will answer by tomorrow, and then we can decide the new date together.”
When will the manager answer?

Tomorrow

Listen for the first sentence.

1 ▶ When will they talk about the goal?

○ On Monday ○ Today ○ Next quarter

2 ▶ What does the employee ask?

○ To lower the goal ○ To get more people ○ To move the date by one week

3 ▶ What does the boss prefer?

○ To read a long report ○ To hear bad news today ○ To hear good news on Friday

7 BOSS?

Can you say it at a meeting?

Read each sentence an employee might say to a boss. Circle the blue thumb if you can say it at a meeting. Circle the pink thumb if it is too much.

		I CAN SAY IT AT A MEETING	TOO MUCH
1	"What does **success** look like for this goal?"		
2	"This goal is **stupid**."		
3	"I will do it. Do not worry."		
4	"You always change the plan at the last minute."		
5	"I see a risk, and I want to tell you today."		
6	"I suggest that we move the date by one week."		
7	"Could you let me know if the new **tool** changes the plan?"		
8	"I need more people, or I will **quit**."		
9	"Sorry, I do not understand anything about this goal."		

8 THE CASE

Marina sets her goal

Marina works in **customer support**. Her boss wants a big goal for the next **quarter**. Look at her **track record** and her **conditions**, then choose a goal that she can **defend**. The numbers are invented for this lesson. They are not real data.

1	ASK FOR CLARITY	**What does success look like? Is 600 the number for every month, or for the whole quarter?** Ask before you guess.
2	SAY IT EARLY	**I see a risk: one person leaves in November, so we will be four, not five.** Say it today, with a fact.
3	DISAGREE CALMLY	**I agree with the goal. The number worries me. Could we start at 520?** Agree first. Then give one fact and one option.
4	ASK FOR WHAT YOU NEED	**I need two weeks to learn the new tool. Could you let me know if it changes the plan?** Name what you need, and say why.

Marina's track record

QUARTER	TICKETS PER MONTH
Last year, Q4	410
Q1	430
Q2	450
Q3	440

Her **average** is about 430 tickets a month.

Her conditions now

One person **leaves** in November. The team goes from five people to four.

A new tool arrives in December. It may help, but nobody knows how much yet, so the calculation does not count it.

Try three goals

With four people, Marina can **keep her pace** and do about 344 tickets a month (430 × 4 ÷ 5). The **score** is 344 divided by the goal. Google says 60 to 70 percent is the **sweet spot** for an ambitious goal.

THE GOAL	LIKELY RESULT	SCORE (LIKELY ÷ GOAL)	IN THE SWEET SPOT?
600	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No
520	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No
480	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No

This is a simple **estimate** for the lesson. A real plan needs more data.

Which of the three goals is in the sweet spot?

Say it to your boss

Marina is talking to her boss. Circle the sentence that follows the pattern.

EXAMPLE Marina wants her boss to explain the priorities.
I'd like you to explain the priorities.
Family 1: would like + person + to + verb.

1 Marina proposes a number: 520.
- ○ I suggest we to set the goal at 520.
- ○ I suggest that we set the goal at 520.
- ○ I suggest that we sets the goal at 520.

2 Marina wants her boss to allow two weeks to learn the new tool.
- ○ Could you let me use two weeks to learn the new tool?
- ○ Could you let me using two weeks to learn the new tool?
- ○ Could you let me to use two weeks to learn the new tool?

3 Marina wants her boss to tell her if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I need that you tell me if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I need you tell me if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I need you to tell me if the tool changes the plan.

Too quiet, say this

Write a better version of each sentence on the line.

1 **No problem**, I can do it.

_____

2 **I will try**.

_____

3 Fine.

_____

4 Sorry, I am **behind**.

_____

5 Nothing is wrong.

_____

YOUR TURN · THE CASE

Choose a goal that you have now, at work or at school. Use the four things to talk to your boss, teacher or coach. Say it out loud, in under one minute.

_____

_____

_____

9 **NOW, AGAIN**

Did the dossier move you?

Same six sentences. Look back at page 1. Did you move?

My boss explains why a goal matters.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I can say "this deadline is too short."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I work better when a goal is a little scary.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A number is better than "do your best."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I tell my boss about a problem early.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I stay quiet when I think my boss will be upset.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Facts come from Gabarro and Kotter, Managing Your Boss, Harvard Business Review (1980), from Detert and Edmondson, Academy of Management Journal (2011), and from Google re:Work. For the Detert and Edmondson study, only the authors, the year and the main idea are given. The four fears, the sentences to say, the Marina numbers and the sample answers are written for this lesson. The comments and the people in the exercises are fictional.